Supplementary Material: Measuring Coordination-Collapse Boundaries in Reward-Mixed Cooperative MARL

Anonymous submission

This document contains the apparatus supporting the main paper: full experimental setup and hyperparameters (§1), the complete loss-aversion sweep and baseline reconciliation (§2), the scoped mean-field derivation (§3), the cross-environment and cross-algorithm detail (§4), both boundary-condition ablations (§5), the pre-registered signal-to-noise probe (§6), the exploration-noise ablation (§7), threshold robustness (§8), notation (§9), and a claim–evidence ledger (§10). Section, equation, and figure references to the main paper are by name. The supply-chain collapse label, analysis code, and mechanism probes were pre-registered before execution as separate commitments (commit hash withheld for anonymity, released on acceptance).

1 Experimental Setup in Full

Primary substrate. `NetworkManagement-v1` from or-gym (Hubbs et al. 2020): a six-node multi-echelon inventory network with Poisson demand (μ=20) on the retail edge, 30-period episodes, uniform lead times. Node 1 (retail-facing) follows a fixed demand-pull policy, stabilizing the demand signal; nodes 2–6 are trained as cooperative PPO agents. Actions are parameterized via a base-stock wrapper mapping each agent's continuous action to a target inventory level $S \in [0, 500]$, with order quantity $Q = \max(0, S - \mathrm{IP})$ where IP is inventory position. The substrate extends prior DRL inventory work, the Beer Distribution Game Dec-POMDP of Oroojlooyjadid et al. (2022), the multi-echelon A3C results of Gijsbrechts et al. (2022), and single-echelon MARL (Leluc et al. 2023), to a six-node network with per-node agents.

Algorithm and evaluation. Each agent runs PPO (Schulman et al. 2017) with a shared MLP policy (`n_steps`=128, `batch_size`=256), implemented with Stable-Baselines3 (Raffin et al. 2021) and PettingZoo/SuperSuit vectorization (Terry et al. 2021; Terry, Black, and Hari 2020). Evaluation is deterministic over 10 episodes with 20 seeds per condition.

Experiment inventory. Table 1 summarizes the seven primary experiments; total run count 1,524.

Basin control (rules out initialization). Exp C rules out initialization as a collapse driver. Within-w correlations between S_{init} and converged S are -0.11 (w=0.5), -0.38 (w=0.85), and -0.36 (w=1.0), small to moderate and inconsistent with initialization dominating; the collapsed/survived assignment is insensitive to where agents start.

Table 1: Primary experiment summary (same environment and algorithm; α=β=1 is the linear no-PT condition).

Exp	Purpose	λ	α, β	Seeds	Runs
A @150k	Struct. boundary	1	1,1	20	220
A @300k	Struct. boundary	1	1,1	20	140
C	Basin control	1	1,1	12	144
N	Null baseline	1	1,1	20	180
B-Red.	Reward-transf. decomp.	1,3,7	0.88	20	300
λ-sweep	Loss-av. law	2,4,5,6	0.88	20	400
T (600k)	Metastability	1	0.88	20	140

Table 2: The recurring w_{crit} values and the single role each plays.

w_{crit}	Condition	Role
0.666	α=β=1, 300k	structural null (main sweep)
0.685	α=β=1, 300k (Exp N)	linear baseline, reproduced
0.822	α=β=1, 150k	null at shorter horizon
0.586	α=β=0.88, λ=1	curvature result

2 Full Reward-Transform Sweep and Baseline Reconciliation

The recurring w_{crit} values. There is one structural null; the other recurring numbers are a horizon measurement of it and a curvature *result*, not independent baselines (Table 2).

Full loss-aversion sweep. Table 3 gives the complete λ=1…7 sweep with Firth penalized fits. The increase is monotone up to estimation noise at the high-λ plateau: w_{crit} rises strictly from λ=1 to λ=5 then saturates near 0.84–0.85 (λ=5, 6 statistically indistinguishable). At high loss aversion the transition is very steep and falls between adjacent grid points (collapse fractions $1.00, 1.00, 1.00, 0.55, 0.00$ at $w \in \{0.5, 0.65, 0.75, 0.85, 0.95\}$ for λ=7), so the boundary remains identifiable (the w=0.85 cell is interior, $11/20$ collapsed) but the unpenalized MLE slope diverges. Firth

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Table 3: Full loss-aversion sweep (α=β=0.88, 300k, 20 seeds/(w, λ) cell, n=100 runs/λ). w_{crit} with bootstrap 95% CIs; slope/p from Firth penalized logistic regression.

λ	w_{crit}	95% CI	Firth b_1	p
1	0.586	[0.539, 0.624]	-14.7	1.2×10^{-6}
2	0.715	[0.687, 0.745]	-27.2	4.4×10^{-6}
3	0.774	[0.751, 0.798]	-29.7	5.1×10^{-6}
4	0.806	[0.766, 0.841]	-36.8	5.5×10^{-6}
5	0.825	[0.806, 0.844]	-53.1	4.7×10^{-4}
6	0.835	[0.817, 0.850]	-24.7	2.5×10^{-6}
7	0.852	[0.841, 0.864]	-43.1	1.5×10^{-3}

penalized logistic regression is stable here; all seven slopes are significant ($p < 10^{-3}$) and the Firth w_{crit} matches the bootstrap to within 0.019, confirming the large unpenalized slopes at λ=5, 7 were a fitting artifact, not separation. The high-λ plateau is a reward-transform saturation, not a w=1 ceiling artifact: at λ=7 no evaluated runs collapse at w=0.95 (collapse fraction 0.00), consistent with the bounded affine law in which $w_{\text{crit}}(\lambda) \to 1$ only as $\lambda \to \infty$. The $\lambda \geq 5$ values in Table 3 use a finer $w \in \{0.80, 0.90\}$ grid added specifically to resolve the steep transition; this places two interior points across each high-λ boundary and halves the CI widths ($0.038, 0.033, 0.024$ at λ=5, 6, 7) relative to the single w=0.85 cell, giving the clean monotone $0.825 \to 0.835 \to 0.852$.

Metastability under matched curvature. The 600k row of the main-paper heatmap uses α=β=0.88, which shifts w_{crit} left by 0.100, so those collapse fractions are partly curvature-deflated. Under matched α=β=1 (Exp 0b, 20 seeds, 600k), $P(\text{collapse} \mid w{=}0.6) = 0.35$ and $P(\text{collapse} \mid w{=}0.7) = 0.20$, versus 0.80 and 0.40 at 300k: the horizon slide holds with curvature held constant; only the figure's 600k magnitude is curvature-inflated.

The metastable slide generalizes. The horizon dependence is not a supply-chain artifact. We ran dedicated horizon sweeps under centralized-critic MAPPO on both transfer environments. On MPE Cooperative Navigation, w_{crit} falls $0.82 \to 0.68$ as the horizon grows 2M $\to$ 8M env steps (slide $+0.14$); on Level-Based Foraging it falls $0.33 \to 0.20$ over 1M $\to$ 4M (slide $+0.13$), each with non-overlapping bootstrap intervals at the endpoints. Both match the supply-chain direction (boundary slides left with more training), so the metastability result (like the loss-aversion direction) holds across environments and algorithms, not just on the primary substrate.

The four-horizon log-linear fit. On the supply chain we measured w_{crit} at four matched risk-neutral horizons (Table 4). The four points fall on a log-linear law $w_{\text{crit}} = 2.44 - 0.138 \ln T$ (RMSE 0.027), the Kramers escape-time prediction that w_{crit} falls as $-\ln T$ toward the deterministic floor $w^0_{\text{crit}} = c/(c+g)$. All four CI widths are $\leq$0.073, and the 300k/450k/900k widths are $\leq$0.054, so the law is a fitted four-point relationship, not a two-point extrapolation.

The derived affine law (18) and its out-of-sample fit (RMSE 0.014 across all seven points) are shown and discussed in the main paper; the derivation of its form is given in §3 below.

Table 4: Matched risk-neutral horizons (α=β=1, λ=1). w_{crit} with bootstrap 95% CIs; the four points fit $w_{\text{crit}} = 2.44 - 0.138 \ln T$ at RMSE 0.027.

T (env steps)	w_{crit}	95% CI
150k	0.822	[0.785, 0.858]
300k	0.666	[0.635, 0.694]
450k	0.622	[0.603, 0.641]
900k	0.573	[0.547, 0.598]

3 Mean-Field Mechanism: Scope and Derivation

This section gives the mechanism underlying the sign-level claims in the main paper. Its scope is deliberately narrow. The derivation is a mean-field account for the primary supply-chain PPO setting, where agents use continuous base-stock actions and the reward-mixing dial w creates a local–global incentive conflict. It is not a closed-form derivation of the numerical value of w_{crit}. The empirical boundary remains calibrated by the fitted collapse curve; the mechanism explains why a boundary exists, why it is sharp at finite horizon, and why loss aversion raises it under a local signal-to-noise premise checked on that substrate.

3.1 Reward transform and policy-mean dynamics

Each trained node i receives the reward-mixed scalar

$$z_i(a) = (1-w)\ell_i(a_i, a_{-i}) + wG(a), \qquad G(a) = \sum_j \ell_j(a), \tag{1}$$

where ℓ_i is the local profit of node i and G is system profit. The prospect-theoretic value transform used in the experiments is

$$v(z) = \begin{cases} z^{\alpha}, & z \geq 0, \\ -\lambda(-z)^{\beta}, & z < 0. \end{cases} \tag{2}$$

Thus the shaped training signal is $r_i^{\text{PT}} = v(z_i)$. We do not model probability weighting in this paper; the experimental transform consists only of value-function curvature (α, β) and loss aversion λ.

For the continuous-action PPO supply-chain substrate, let m_i denote the mean of agent i's Gaussian base-stock policy. Around a slowly varying policy state, the stochastic PPO update of m_i can be approximated by the diffusion

$$\mathrm{d}m_i = F_i(m; w, \alpha, \beta, \lambda)\,\mathrm{d}t + \sqrt{\Sigma_i(m; w, \alpha, \beta, \lambda)}\,\mathrm{d}W_i, \tag{3}$$

where F_i is the expected policy-mean drift and $\Sigma_i > 0$ is the variance of the stochastic update. We use F only for drift and Σ only for diffusion variance. Constant factors in the diffusion convention, such as whether one writes $\sqrt{\Sigma}$ or $\sqrt{2\Theta}$, are absorbed into the critical signal-to-noise threshold below and do not affect any sign claim.

3.2 The local–global incentive conflict

The primary supply-chain substrate has the incentive asymmetry required for a collapse boundary. Along the base-stock direction, increasing an upstream node's stock is locally costly because it increases holding and procurement costs, but globally beneficial because it prevents downstream stockouts. A finite-difference probe of the substrate gives the local signs

$$\partial_a \mathbb{E}[\ell_i] \approx -c, \qquad \partial_a \mathbb{E}[G] \approx +g, \qquad c, g > 0. \tag{4}$$

Ignoring the prospect transform and stochastic-update variance, the cooperative component of the policy-mean drift has the form

$$F_0(w) = \eta\{wg - (1-w)c\}. \tag{5}$$

The deterministic zero-drift crossing is therefore

$$w^0_{\mathrm{crit}} = \frac{c}{c+g}. \tag{6}$$

This is not the empirical boundary measured in the paper. It is only the low-noise, infinite-horizon floor toward which the finite-horizon boundary can move. At finite horizon, stochastic updates and basin geometry make the operative boundary a signal-to-noise crossing, not merely the point where the deterministic drift changes sign.

3.3 Collapse as failure to escape the lazy basin

Let $x \in [0,1]$ be a latent order parameter measuring progress from the lazy basin toward coordinated behavior. We do not claim that x is directly observed in the experiments. It is a macroscopic coordinate used to describe the basin-level dynamics:

$$\mathrm{d}x_t = F(x_t, w, \lambda)\,\mathrm{d}t + \sqrt{\Sigma(x_t, w, \lambda, N)}\,\mathrm{d}W_t. \tag{7}$$

Here F is the effective drift toward coordination and Σ is the stochastic-update variance. Let $\tau_{L\to C}(w,\lambda)$ denote the mean first-passage time to escape the lazy basin and reach the coordinating basin.

This convention fixes the direction of the argument. A run is collapsed at training horizon T when it has not escaped the lazy basin by the end of training:

$$\text{collapse at horizon } T \quad \Longleftrightarrow \quad \tau_{L\to C}(w,\lambda) > T \tag{8}$$

up to the usual stochastic first-passage variability. The empirical midpoint $w^{\mathrm{Emp}}_{\mathrm{crit}}(T,\lambda)$ is the value of w at which the fitted collapse probability equals $1/2$, equivalently the finite-horizon crossing where the typical escape time is on the order of T.

Increasing w strengthens the cooperative global component of the reward, so it decreases $\tau_{L\to C}$. Increasing loss aversion weakens the effective escape signal relative to update noise in the loss domain, so it increases $\tau_{L\to C}$. Therefore a larger w is required to reach the same fixed-horizon crossing when λ increases.

3.4 Signal-to-noise form of the boundary

The quantity that matters near the boundary is not drift alone, but escape signal-to-noise. Define the local escape SNR

$$\mathcal{S}(w,\lambda) = \frac{F_{\mathrm{esc}}(w,\lambda)}{\sqrt{\Sigma_{\mathrm{esc}}(w,\lambda)}}, \tag{9}$$

where F_{esc} and Σ_{esc} denote the effective drift and update variance on the escape interval from the lazy basin to the coordinating basin. The finite-horizon boundary is the crossing

$$\mathcal{S}(w,\lambda) \approx \kappa_T, \tag{10}$$

where κ_T is a horizon-dependent critical value. Longer training horizons require a smaller escape SNR, so $w_{\mathrm{crit}}(T)$ decreases with T. This gives the metastable interpretation of the observed horizon slide: at any fixed training budget the boundary is well-defined, but additional training can rescue some policies below the shorter-horizon boundary.

Equivalently, in the one-dimensional diffusion approximation, Kramers' first-passage form gives

$$\tau_{L\to C}(w,\lambda) \asymp \tau_0 \exp\{\Delta U_{L\to C}(w,\lambda)\}, \tag{11}$$

where $\Delta U_{L\to C}$ is the effective quasi-potential barrier for leaving the lazy basin. Larger escape SNR lowers this barrier and shortens $\tau_{L\to C}$; lower escape SNR raises the barrier and lengthens $\tau_{L\to C}$. The numerical value of $\Delta U_{L\to C}$ depends on the unobserved covariance structure of PPO updates, so the mechanism does not produce a closed-form numerical w_{crit}.

3.5 Sign propagation under a checked local premise

The sign claim used in the main paper is conditional on a local premise, checked on the supply-chain substrate, about how w and λ affect the escape SNR.

Premise. On the supply-chain PPO escape interval,

$$\partial_w \mathcal{S}(w,\lambda) > 0, \qquad \partial_\lambda \mathcal{S}(w,\lambda) < 0. \tag{12}$$

The first inequality states that increasing centralization strengthens the escape signal. The second states that increasing loss aversion lowers the effective escape signal-to-noise ratio. This second effect may arise through drift, diffusion, or both: loss aversion changes the transformed reward landscape in the loss domain and can increase stochastic update variance relative to the cooperative escape signal. We therefore state the premise at the SNR level rather than identifying it with drift alone.

Proposition 1 (Loss aversion raises the empirical boundary)**.** *Assume the local SNR premise above and assume the mean escape time $\tau_{L\to C}$ is strictly decreasing in $\mathcal{S}$. Then, at fixed training horizon T,*

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}w^{\mathrm{Emp}}_{\mathrm{crit}}}{\mathrm{d}\lambda} > 0. \tag{13}$$

Proof. The empirical boundary is the fixed-horizon crossing

$$\tau_{L\to C}(w,\lambda) = T. \tag{14}$$

Since $\tau_{L\to C}$ decreases with escape SNR and $\partial_w \mathcal{S} > 0$, we have $\partial_w \tau_{L\to C} < 0$. Since $\partial_\lambda \mathcal{S} < 0$, increasing loss aversion lengthens the lazy-to-coordination escape time: $\partial_\lambda \tau_{L\to C} > 0$. Applying the implicit function theorem to $H(w, \lambda) = \tau_{L\to C}(w, \lambda) - T = 0$ gives

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}w_{\mathrm{crit}}^{\mathrm{Emp}}}{\mathrm{d}\lambda} = -\frac{\partial_\lambda \tau_{L\to C}}{\partial_w \tau_{L\to C}} > 0. \tag{15}$$

The proposition proves only the direction. Its magnitude depends on the unobserved diffusion and basin geometry, which is why the empirical boundary is measured rather than predicted in closed form. □

3.6 Curvature is scoped to the primary substrate

The same SNR language explains why value-function curvature and loss aversion can move the boundary in opposite directions on the primary supply-chain PPO substrate. In that setting, concave value curvature ($\alpha, \beta < 1$) compresses reward variation and empirically raises the escape SNR relative to the linear transform, lowering w_{crit}. Loss aversion magnifies the loss-domain component and lowers the escape SNR, raising w_{crit}.

This curvature sign is not claimed to be universal. It is a primary-substrate result. The transfer experiments show that the loss-aversion direction generalizes, while the curvature sign and exact functional form are substrate-specific. Thus the mechanism supports the supply-chain decomposition and the sign of the loss-aversion shift, but it does not claim a global curvature theorem for all cooperative MARL tasks.

3.7 Affine loss-aversion law on the supply-chain substrate

The supply-chain PPO sweep is additionally summarized by a bounded one-parameter law after anchoring the baseline. At $\lambda = 1$, the curvature baseline fixes the ratio g/c through

$$w_{\mathrm{crit}}(1) = \frac{1}{1 + g/c}. \tag{16}$$

Loss aversion scales only the loss-domain share of the marginal escape incentive. Writing that share as $\rho \in [0, 1]$, define

$$\phi(\lambda) = 1 + \rho(\lambda - 1). \tag{17}$$

The resulting bounded form is

$$w_{\mathrm{crit}}(\lambda) = \frac{\phi(\lambda)}{\phi(\lambda) + g/c}. \tag{18}$$

This is not a free closed-form prediction of the numerical boundary. The baseline anchors g/c, and ρ is one additional calibrated parameter. The useful content is that the form is monotone, bounded, and saturating. In the supply-chain PPO sweep, fitting ρ on the calibration points and testing on held-out λ values gives the reported small held-out error; the leave-one-out calculation is a stability check, not a replacement for the original calibration split.

The affine law is therefore a single-substrate mechanism summary. It is not claimed to transfer to LBF or MPE, where the absolute levels, curvature sign, and functional form differ.

Table 5: What the mean-field mechanism claims after separating modeled signs from calibrated quantities.

Category	Claim
Modeled, not fitted	On the primary supply-chain PPO substrate: increasing w raises escape SNR; increasing λ lowers escape SNR; therefore loss aversion raises w_{crit}. Finite-horizon escape gives sharpness and a leftward horizon slide.
Empirically confirmed	Sharp boundary; horizon slide; loss-aversion direction across SC, MPE, and LBF; entropy-noise dissociation where injected noise is binding.
Calibrated/fitted	Absolute w_{crit}; diffusion scale; g/c from the baseline; one additional affine-law parameter ρ after baseline anchoring.
Not claimed	Closed-form numerical w_{crit}; universal curvature sign; transfer of the affine law beyond the supply-chain PPO substrate; direct observability of the latent order parameter.

4 Generalization Detail

4.1 Cross-environment: MPE Cooperative Navigation

Three agents cover three landmarks in a continuous 2-D arena (discrete actions, 50-step episodes). The locally rational action under the herding incentive is to stay near teammates, collectively disastrous, as agents cluster and no landmark is covered. We set `local_ratio`$=0$ so the raw reward is the pure global team score; the herding term is defined by our wrapper. Collapse is per-step landmark occupancy (fraction of landmarks within a fixed radius of some agent), an evaluation metric invariant to reward scale and so unaffected by the reward transform. Unlike the supply chain (per-agent incentives), MPE's coordination reward is shared-global, which under independent learners confounds reward-transform collapse with credit-assignment failure; we therefore train MPE with centralized-critic MAPPO (Yu et al. 2022; Lowe et al. 2017). We set the herding scale so the null boundary is interior (w_{crit}=0.74) and ran the full λ-sweep (1,760 runs, 20 seeds/cell; Figure 1). The loss-aversion effect replicates, w_{crit} rises $0.78 \to 0.89$ over λ=1 $\to$ 7, rising in envelope but non-monotone at intermediate λ, excess $+0.158$ $[0.108, 0.212]$ at λ=7 and $+0.101$ $[0.055, 0.150]$ at λ=3 (matching the supply chain's $+0.089$). The curvature effect does *not* replicate ($+0.042$ $[-0.009, 0.092]$, opposite in sign), and the affine form fits MPE only to RMSE 0.05.

4.2 A third environment: Level-Based Foraging

LBF (Christianos, Schäfer, and Albrecht 2020) has a public-goods incentive: agents pay an effort cost to load food cooperatively, so the locally rational action is to free-ride. Natively discrete, unrelated to logistics or navigation, trained under centralized-critic MAPPO (matching MPE so only the

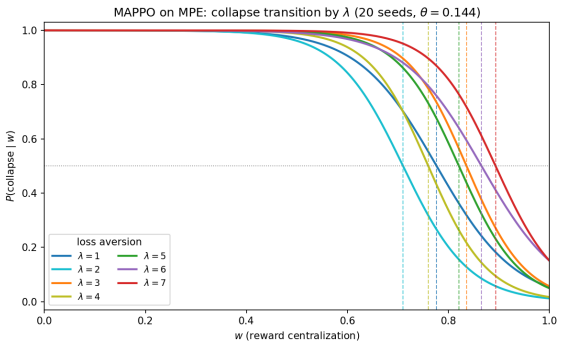


Figure 1: MAPPO on MPE Cooperative Navigation: fitted $P(\text{collapse} \mid w)$ for λ=1, . . . , 7 (α=β=0.88, centralized critic, collapse = landmark occupancy below θ=0.144). The family shifts rightward with λ, the same loss-aversion signature, under a different environment and algorithm.

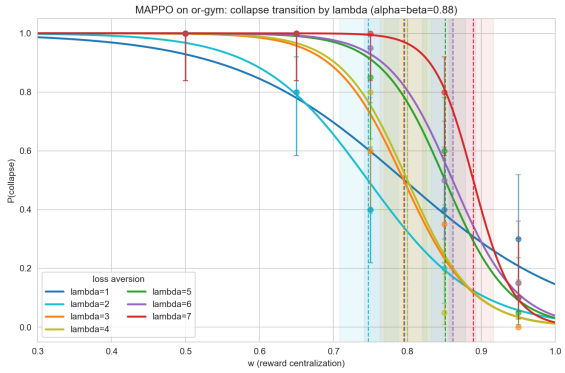


Figure 2: Centralized-critic MAPPO on the supply chain: $P(\text{collapse} \mid w)$ for λ=1, . . . , 7 (700 runs). As under PPO, the family shifts rightward with loss aversion, confirming the effect is not an artifact of independent PPO.

environment varies), full λ-sweep, same collapse-midpoint criterion (1,600 runs). The risk-neutral null is low and tight ($w_{\text{crit}} \approx 0.08$); curvature moves it *right* by $+0.18$ (opposite to the supply chain). Loss aversion drives w_{crit} from 0.26 at λ=1 to 0.83 at λ=4, monotone with non-overlapping endpoint CIs (the pre-registered criterion), robust to the collapse threshold. For $\lambda \geq 5$ the boundary saturates against the centralization ceiling: the logistic w_{crit} extrapolates to $w \geq 1$ (outside the measured $w \in [0, 0.95]$ grid), so these points are *not* interior estimates and we label them exploratory in the precise sense that their w_{crit} lies beyond the range any run samples, their location is bounded below by 0.95 but not upper-bounded by the data. An added intermediate level w=0.90 tightens the mid-λ estimates and confirms the saturation, but does not bring the $\lambda \geq 5$ crossings inside the grid. The supply chain's affine law does not transfer: with γ fixed from λ=1, the best-fit slope saturates at its bound and misfits LBF by RMSE 0.15, converting the form's substrate-specificity from assertion to measured result.

4.3 Cross-algorithm: MAPPO on the supply chain

To isolate the algorithm from the environment, we rerun the full sweep on the *identical* substrate, grid, seeds, label, and hyperparameters, changing only the learner from independent PPO to centralized-critic MAPPO (700 runs; Figure 2). w_{crit} rises $0.796\,[0.742, 0.860]$ at λ=1 to $0.889\,[0.856, 0.917]$ at λ=7, monotone from λ=2 ($0.747, 0.795, 0.800, 0.851, 0.861, 0.889$), endpoint CIs non-overlapping. The direction generalizes while the absolute level does not: MAPPO sits above PPO at low λ (most visibly λ=1, 0.796 vs 0.586, where MAPPO's transition is shallow and the estimate noisier), converging by $\lambda \geq 4$ ($|\Delta w_{\text{crit}}| \leq 0.04$).

Table 6: Action-representation ablation. The control (last row) changes only the action space while holding the learner at PPO, isolating coarse discretization, not the value-based paradigm, as what erases the boundary.

Learner	Action space	Boundary?
PPO / MAPPO	continuous	yes
QMIX (centralized value)	discrete K=11	no
IQL (independent value)	discrete K=11	no
PPO (control)	discrete K=11	**no**

5 Two Boundary-Condition Ablations

5.1 Action representation

For the supply-chain base-stock control, the mechanism predicts that coarse discretization of the scalar action representation can remove the near-boundary crossing. Value-based learners need discrete actions, so we discretized the base-stock control into K=11 bins and ran IQL and QMIX on the identical reward pipeline, w-grid, and label; both produced a flat, w-independent collapse rate with no fittable w_{crit}. To isolate the cause, a single-variable control (PPO on the same K=11 discrete shell) also goes flat (Table 6). Discretization *alone* erases the boundary, so the value-based nulls need no appeal to the learning paradigm. This is not a claim that discreteness per se removes the boundary: MPE is natively discrete and retains it. Coarse bins snap the policy to a stable interior level and never visit the near-threshold (s, S) region where collapse occurs, exactly the continuous-gradient prediction. The effect is a coarse-discretization boundary condition, substrate-specific like the curvature sign, and a confirmed scope condition.

5.2 Credit assignment

The boundary is measurable only with a learner that can coordinate on a shared-reward task. On MPE, independent PPO never reaches the coordinated regime at *any* w (collapse fraction 1.0 throughout, including maximal centralization; Figure 3), so collapse induced by the reward trans-

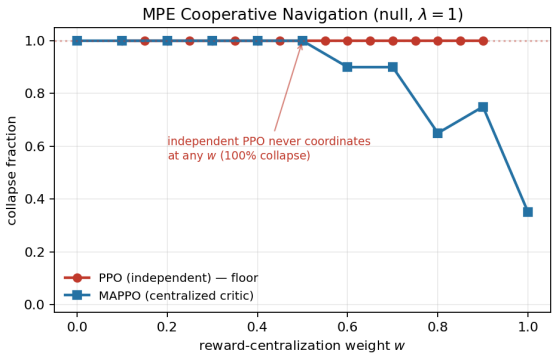


Figure 3: Credit-assignment ablation on MPE (null, λ=1). Independent PPO collapses at every w (a coordination floor), while centralized-critic MAPPO crosses the boundary. The reward-transform boundary is exposed only once credit assignment is handled.

form cannot be distinguished from inability to assign credit. Centralized-critic MAPPO recovers coordination (collapse fraction falls to 0.35, occupancy crosses the threshold near $w \approx 0.6$). The same floor appears on LBF. The boundary is therefore measurable on these shared-reward tasks only with a centralized critic. Matching MAPPO to such environments is a necessity, not a convenience.

6 Pre-registered Signal-to-Noise Probe

The mean-field account calibrates the magnitude of w_{crit} rather than predicting it, because the drift and diffusion coefficients are properties of the stochastic PPO learning dynamics. We pre-registered a direct measurement intended to test whether these coefficients could localize the boundary. During PPO training we logged the policy mean once per update and, over a fixed early window, estimated an empirical drift $\widehat{F}(w)$ from mean increments and an empirical diffusion variance $\widehat{\Sigma}(w)$ from increment variance. We formed

$$\widehat{\mathcal{S}}(w) = \frac{\widehat{F}(w)}{\sqrt{\widehat{\Sigma}(w)}}. \tag{19}$$

If one uses the alternative convention $\Sigma = 2\Theta$, the constant factor is absorbed into the critical threshold and does not change any crossing or sign claim. **Boundary-reproduction check:** sweep $w \in \{0.50, \ldots, 0.90\}$ at the structural condition, 20 seeds/w, 150k steps; the measured collapse-fraction crossing should reproduce the matched-horizon boundary $w_{\text{crit}} = 0.822$. **Outcome (reported in full):** the collapse-fraction of this independent sweep crosses 0.5 at $w = 0.82$, reproducing the matched-horizon boundary almost exactly, a positive robustness check on the boundary. The *drift-sign* observable, however, was *inconclusive*: the restoring drift in the contested band is weakly positive across all w with no genuine zero-crossing, so it does not localize w_{crit}. The reason is basin geometry, PPO initializes above the cooperative optimum (S≈250 vs S≈150), and collapses plunge through the contested band too quickly to sample, biasing the conditioned drift toward survivors.

Table 7: Entropy-coefficient ablation (α=β=1, λ=1, 300k, 20 seeds/cell). w_{crit} with bootstrap 95% CIs.

entropy coef.	w_{crit} (95% CI)
0.000	0.685 [0.656, 0.710]
0.001	0.690 [0.667, 0.715]
0.010	0.715 [0.689, 0.743]
0.050	> 1 (collapse at all w)

Non-survivor-biased re-probe (also negative). We tested the natural fix directly. We re-ran the identical sweep with the policy re-initialized at the cooperative optimum (S≈150, actor mean biased to a_0=−0.4) so that both surviving and collapsing runs are sampled inside the contested band during early training, and added a second, initialization-robust *basin-flow* localizer (net early displacement of the policy mean from the optimum) alongside the restoring-drift statistic. The re-initialization de-biased the observable (the drift is now smooth and monotone in w rather than flat and noisy) and the collapse-fraction crossing again reproduced the boundary ($w_{\text{crit}} \approx 0.83$). But neither statistic *localizes* w_{crit}: the drift and basin-flow are monotone in w without a zero-crossing, and their steepest change falls near w≈0.6, not at the boundary. The observable therefore tracks *where the policy sits* rather than *where the boundary is*, which the initialization change does not fix. We consequently report magnitude localization as genuinely open: the sign-level account and single-substrate functional-form summary remain useful, but a magnitude-level prediction of w_{crit} remains future work. The re-probe driver and analysis are released with the code.

7 Exploration-Noise Ablation

The SNR account predicts that injected exploration noise raises w_{crit} when it is the binding SNR term. Sweeping the PPO entropy coefficient at the structural condition (300k, 20 seeds, $w \in \{0.5, \ldots, 0.9\}$), the supply-chain boundary rises monotonically: $w_{\text{crit}} = 0.685$ at ent=0 (reproducing the null), 0.690 at 0.001, 0.715 at 0.01, and beyond 0.05 the system collapses at every tested w (Table 7). **A binding-noise dissociation.** Repeating under MAPPO on the transfer substrates: on LBF the prediction replicates (w_{crit} rises $0.13 \to 0.37$ over ent $\in \{0, 0.05\}$, shift +0.24, non-overlapping endpoints); on MPE the boundary does *not* move (shift +0.05, overlapping CIs; pooled slope over 1,320 runs positive but not significant, β=+0.47, CI $[-3.4, +4.3]$). This is a dissociation predicted by the mechanism: exploration noise moves the boundary only when it is the binding term in the SNR. The supply chain and LBF have sparse, sharp landscapes where injected entropy dominates; MPE's dense distance-shaped reward carries high intrinsic exploration that swamps the added term. The pattern matches the binding-noise criterion: the boundary moves where injected entropy is binding and is statistically flat where it is not.

8 Threshold Robustness

We re-estimate w_{crit} on Exp A @300k under nine variants of the collapse definition, varying the $\bar{S}$ threshold over $\{8, 10, 12\}$ and the $\bar{\pi}$ threshold over $\{-102.5, -127.1, -152.5\}$. Three variants with $\bar{\pi} \leq -152.5$ are degenerate (the minimum profit in the dataset is -128.1) and excluded. Across the remaining six estimable variants the maximum deviation from the baseline $w_{\mathrm{crit}} = 0.666$ is 0.015, well below the CI width: the collapse definition is robust to $\pm 20\%$ threshold perturbation.

9 Notation and Abbreviations

Symbol	Meaning
w	reward centralization weight, $\in [0, 1]$
w_{crit}	critical w where $P(\mathrm{collapse})$=0.5
λ	loss-aversion coefficient (λ>1)
α, β	prospect-theoretic value-function curvature (gain/loss)
ρ	loss-domain share of marginal incentive, $\in [0, 1]$
g, c	marginal global benefit / local cost of cooperation
F, Σ	policy-mean drift / stochastic-update diffusion variance
$\mathcal{S}(w, \lambda)$	$F_{\mathrm{esc}}/\sqrt{\Sigma_{\mathrm{esc}}}$, escape signal-to-noise ratio
σ, η, B	exploration scale / learning rate / batch size
$\Delta U, \tau$	escape barrier / Kramers first-passage time
T	training horizon (environment steps)
$\bar{S}, \bar{\pi}$	mean base-stock / mean profit (collapse label)

Abbreviations. MARL (multi-agent reinforcement learning); CTDE (centralized training, decentralized execution); PT value transform (prospect-theoretic value transform); PPO (proximal policy optimization); MAPPO (multi-agent PPO with a centralized critic); MPE (multi-agent particle environments); LBF (Level-Based Foraging); SNR (signal-to-noise ratio); CI (confidence interval).

10 Claim–Evidence Ledger

Table 8 assigns each headline claim to its evidence bucket. The loss-aversion direction is the generalizing core; the curvature sign, affine law, and downstream-minority cascade are supply-chain-specific unless separately replicated.

Table 8: Claim ledger after the final scope pass. SC = supply chain.

Claim	Evidence bucket
Sharp collapse boundary w_{crit} exists	measured generally (SC, MPE, LBF; PPO/MAPPO)
Metastability: w_{crit} slides with T	measured generally (SC, MPE, LBF; PPO/MAPPO)
Loss aversion raises w_{crit}	measured generally for direction (SC, MPE, LBF; PPO/MAPPO)
Curvature lowers w_{crit}	measured only on SC PPO; not universal
Affine λ-law	calibrated/fitted on SC PPO only
Mean-field sign account	modeled/sign-level under SC PPO SNR premise
Downstream-minority cascade	measured only on SC PPO; future work for other directed-flow domains
Closed-form numerical w_{crit}	future work

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